severe India–China confrontation since the 1980s increased Indian awareness that it might find itself in a fight against China without strong US support. Finally, India is aware that strong alignment could aggravate insecurity by provoking strong reactions from the potential adversary.

Instead of moving even closer to the United States, it could also be that India chooses hedging in the anticipation of its own rise as a true counterweight to China. According to estimates from the International Monetary Fund, India's GDP will grow by an annual average of 7.3 percent in the 2020–2024 period, while China's GDP is estimated to grow by an average of 5.7 percent. It will take India many years to close the gap with China, as India's GDP in 2018 accounted for only 20 percent of that of China. However, in terms of purchasing power parity, India's economy has slowly started to close the gap with China and will by 2024 account for 45 percent of China's. Still, it may take another two to three decades at least before India rises as the third pole in a multipolar Asia, but if such a scenario plays out, it would of course alter the dynamics.

With great-power interests at play, the forces of ideology and nationalism could also become part of the mix of issues shaping the future of Asia and India–China relations. In their respective chapters, Muni and Xavier both refer to how India now includes culture and ideology as tools in its diplomatic contest with China over influence in neighbouring countries. At the Party Congress in 2017, China's leader Xi Jinping stated that his country is now ready to serve as a model for others, something China so far has refrained from actively promoting since the end of the Cold War. Ideology and growing nationalism in the context of great power rivalry could contribute to consolidate and reinforce lines of division and also lead to growing emphasis on mercantilist economic policies over free trade and globalisation.

This brings us to a third issue India has to consider, and that is the gravity of economic interdependence versus